



Digital SLR test



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Sony A200



easily the heaviest of the entry-level dSLRs. The quality of the camera is pretty good, although it feels of plastic almost all over.

The display quality of the 2.7-inch LCD screen is average. Sony has brought in colourful menus to the dSLR and everything looks very user-friendly, but there's little help to guide users through the menus. The buttons on the back for operating the camera are well considered. The direction key set, for example, lets you scroll through images diagonally. The buttons are flat, soft and effortless to use. But wear and tear on them through months of rough use might concern some.

The controls are placed in different areas of the camera and not cramped all together. This might be comfortable for use once you get used to this kind of layout, but it also means that you have to move your fingers all over the camera to access them. It's probably not the most optimal layout. While dSLRs try to give users the quickest access to controls, the A200 has a few settings hidden away behind a Function button. These include the flash mode, metering and autofocus mode settings. Noise reduction features for ISO and long exposure shots are also present.

We're quite impressed by the features and design effort that Sony has put into this entry-level dSLR. One such feature is a meter that measures the amount of movement while you are taking a photograph. A flashing indicator next to it warns you of it. The stabilization control is present as a simple slider on one corner of the camera and not on the lens. The stabilization is average, but just the warning is enough to get your attention and put that extra care into holding the camera steady.

The other very impressive feature is the flash. With almost everything automated, the flash is able to measure the light very accurately. We tried all kinds of shots with objects really close and some moderately far away. The amount of light

fired is accurate and the backgrounds are rarely drowned in darkness. If you think that the flash on the Sony isn't sufficient, then you might face a problem. Sony uses a different flash-mount compared to Canon and Nikon, so purchasing a third-party flash might turn out to be a bit of a problem. It must be said that this mount feels more solid than the rest. The grip too is a little nicer than on the Canon cameras.

Image stabilisation is present on the camera and not on the lens with the Sony A200. A sensor detects your face in front of the eyepiece and then turns on the focussing and turns off the LCD, as with some of the other cameras. Those with high-definition TVs and monitors will be interested to know that this camera shoots at 16:9 aspect ratios. This means you don't have to go through the trouble of cropping every single photo manually or automating it using an image editor, which often can crop out areas of interest to you.

The camera isn't very fast and the drive speed at 3 frames per second is also not as impressive as the upper-end cameras, but it does easily make a match for other cameras of its category. The A200 uses CompactFlash memory and not Sony's proprietary Memory Stick Duo like its point-and-shoot cameras.

The Verdict (s)

Knowing how great are the variations between P&S cameras, the case with dSLRs is quite different. The cameras we received were all very good in their own way. One thing's for sure though — it's safe to assume (at least most of the time), good quality comes at higher cost.

Roughly, the Nikon D60, the Sony A200 and the two Canons — the EOS 1000D and the EOS 400D fell into the basic entry-level range of dSLR cameras. Our conclusion is that the Nikon D60 is a

better camera than the rest. This is mainly because of the features and the functionality of the camera. One of the very valid points emphasised by Manas and something with which we all fully agreed on was that the D60 was an easier dSLR to use, and the quality of the body and feel was far better than the rest. Of the two Canons, we felt that the 400D was better than the very new 1000D.

The 1000D has a weird dusty feel to it and holding gives not the nicest and most confident feeling one can get. This was one of the D60's biggest plus points. The EOS 400D was better in that aspect. As cameras, the 1000D is a little refined in its menus and interface. The EOS 400D we feel is the better of the two Canons, and right behind the D60 in our idea of the optimal camera for a beginner. The Sony A200 is a slightly different story. The camera is a nifty little thing with its features and menus. It caught us by surprise, and was not what we expected from Sony. Unfortunately, some of the complaints concern the average build quality of the lens and the feel of the camera. The body is solid, but its feel isn't so great. It's also a slightly noisy camera when you let it loose to autofocus all the time. Market prices might differ from MRPs. The Sony A200 is a decent camera, if it's a lot cheaper than the D60.

The next cameras we need to consider are the Nikon D80 and the D90. The D90 was called in to replace the D80 and it does that easily. Although the video recording feature might not be on every photography enthusiast's wish list, it's the Live View that will interest many. As much as people would dismiss it, it's a feature useful in many situations and that's an edge the P&S always had. The D90 is on a par on that front now. The D90's Live View works pretty well and the video quality is better than that found with many of the point and shoots cameras. Should you buy the D90? Yes! If you are looking for something better than the D60, then it is miles ahead, and also ahead of the D80. The D80 now is left to slip out of the market, as the D90 takes centre stage. If prices seem attractive and photo shooting is all you want, it might be something to consider if you don't mind buying outdated technology. The MRP for the older D80 is Rs. 70,950 with the 18-135 mm lens and Rs. 83,950 for the D90 with the VR 18-105 mm lens. Market prices might be lower.

There is no better way to describe the Canon EOS 50D. As a mid-ranged prosumer dSLR, it doesn't come much better. Nikon's D90 is a great dSLR and also a video camera, but the Canon EOS 50D is a better photographer's camera. The price for it is a whopping Rs. 81,995, which includes the EF-S 18-55 mm f/3.5-5.6 IS kit lens. It's not the best value for money product considering the 18-55 mm lens that comes with it, but it's a camera we recommend if you have the money to splurge. ■

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Contact Sheet

DSLR Comparison Test

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